

RESEARCH PROPOSAL FOR MASTER OF SCIENCE IN HOME SCIENCE (MHCP-002)

Program Name: Master of Science in Home Science (Community Development & Extension Management) — MSCHSC

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Course Code: MHCP-002

Regional Centre: Darbhanga (Regional Centre Code: 46)

Study Centre: Muzaffarpur (Study Centre Code: 0504)

Research Supervisor: Dr. Rajni Pandey

Project Title

- Women Participation in Decision Making Bodies: A Study of Barriers and Enablers

Introduction

Women's participation in decision-making bodies is an essential pillar for fostering inclusive and equitable governance, particularly in rural regions like Chhattarpur, a prominent block in Palamu district, Jharkhand. While urban centers often dominate narratives of progress, Chhattarpur and its surrounding rural areas provide a powerful example of how women, when empowered, can reshape local governance. Historically, leadership and decision-making in Chhattarpur, like many rural pockets of India, have been male-dominated, with cultural norms and economic structures sidelining women from leadership roles. Yet, over the past few decades, this narrative has begun to shift. Government policies, such as the reservation of seats for women in panchayats, combined with grassroots initiatives from local self-help groups and NGOs, have begun to create ripples of change. In Chhattarpur, women are no longer passive observers; they are becoming key players in shaping policies that affect agriculture, education, health, and infrastructure in their communities. As women step into panchayat leadership, they bring fresh perspectives, challenging traditional hierarchies and ensuring that policies are more responsive to women's needs. However, this journey is not without obstacles. Deeply ingrained social norms, economic dependency on male members, and limited access to education act as persistent barriers. Many women, despite holding leadership roles, still rely on male relatives for decision-making support, and structural inequities limit their long-term impact. In this research, we delve into the specific socio-economic conditions of Chhattarpur's rural areas, analyzing the enablers—such as local women's self-help groups, skill development programs, and educational initiatives—that support women's leadership. By comparing different villages within Chhattarpur, we uncover both the progress made and the gaps that still remain. This exploration not only highlights the transformative potential of women in local governance but also offers a model for other rural areas in Jharkhand and beyond, where women are striving to break barriers and

redefine leadership.

Statement of the Problem

Despite constitutional reservations and increasing awareness, women in rural areas, such as Chhattarpur in Palamu, Jharkhand, remain significantly underrepresented in decision-making bodies. Although women's reservation in local governance has been legally mandated, their actual participation is hindered by deep-seated social norms, economic dependency, lack of educational opportunities, and limited access to resources. As a result, even when women occupy formal leadership roles, they often have minimal influence on critical decisions. Many women leaders continue to depend on male family members for guidance and support in decision-making processes. This gap limits the effectiveness of local governance, as women's perspectives, needs, and contributions are essential for balanced, inclusive policy-making. Therefore, a distinct academic necessity exists to study the specific factors affecting women's participation in decision-making bodies and identify ways to strengthen their leadership and empowerment.

Objectives of the Study

General Objective

- To understand the determinants, barriers, and outcomes of women's participation in decision-making bodies and its effect on the quality of local governance in Chhattarpur, Palamu, Jharkhand.

Specific Objectives

- To examine the current level of women's participation in decision-making bodies in Chhattarpur, Palamu.
- To identify key social, economic, and cultural barriers that limit women's decision-making power.
- To analyze how supportive factors, such as self-help groups, education, and policy interventions, enable women's leadership.
- To compare women's experiences across different villages in Chhattarpur to identify patterns of success and challenges.
- To propose practical strategies and policy recommendations for enhancing women's decision-making capacity.
- To explore the impact of women's participation on the quality of local governance and community development.

Hypotheses

- **Hypothesis:** Women's participation in decision-making bodies in Chhattarpur, Palamu will foster a more inclusive governance structure by ensuring that women's perspectives and issues are integrated into policy discussions.
- **Hypothesis:** As women take on leadership roles, it is hypothesized that policies will become more equitable, addressing gender-specific needs in education, healthcare, and

economic opportunities.

- **Hypothesis:** By amplifying women's voices in leadership, decision-making will become more representative of the entire community, not just traditional male leadership.
- **Hypothesis:** As a result, gender disparities—such as unequal access to resources, decision-making influence, and social services—will gradually diminish, leading to a more balanced and just governance structure in these rural communities.

Universe of the Study

- The universe of the study consists of women from rural areas of Chhattarpur Block, Palamu district, Jharkhand.
- For this research, a field survey will be conducted among approximately 50–60 women who are associated with Gram Panchayats, self-help groups (SHGs), and other community activities or are influenced by local decision-making processes.
- The study aims to understand women's participation in decision-making bodies, the challenges they face, and the factors that influence their empowerment and leadership in rural governance.

Sample and Sampling Design

- The study will be conducted within specifically selected rural villages located under the Chhattarpur block, Palamu district, Jharkhand.
- The final sample size will consist of 50–60 women respondents chosen from the targeted universe.
- The target respondents will include women involved in Panchayati Raj institutions, self-help groups (SHGs), and active community development projects.
- **Purposive Sampling Method:** This non-probability sampling approach will be used to explicitly select women who hold formal positions or actively participate in decision-making activities (such as elected members and group leaders).
- **Random Sampling Method:** This probability method will be paired alongside purposive sampling to select general members from different villages, ensuring equal representation and eliminating contextual bias.
- The selected sample will effectively represent the level of women's participation, barriers, and supportive factors in local decision-making bodies.

Tools for Data Collection

- **Questionnaire:** A set of structured, choice-based questions will be distributed to collect standardized, quantitative data from respondents.
- **Interview Schedule:** Personal, face-to-face interviews will be conducted with women participants, local leaders, and community members to obtain deeply descriptive, qualitative details.
- **Observation Method:** The researcher will use an observational guide to assess women's real-time confidence, vocal involvement, and physical participation in meetings and local governance activities.
- **Focus Group Discussion (FGD):** Moderated group discussions will be organized to understand collective community opinions, social taboos, and shared experiences of

women.

- **Secondary Sources:** Supporting literature and baseline metrics will be gathered from government portals, books, research articles, census data, and certified NGO records.

Sample Questions and Points for Tool Section

Interview Schedule Items

- What is your age and highest educational qualification?
- Are you involved in any decision-making body, panchayat, or local village committee?
- How often do you physically participate in scheduled community meetings?
- Do you feel confident while expressing your opinions and counter-views openly in meetings?
- What major socio-economic challenges do women face when taking on leadership roles?
- Does your family structure support your active participation in public and administrative activities?
- How has active women's participation affected development works in your village?
- What practical steps can be taken to improve women's autonomous decision-making power?

Observation Points Guide

- Physical attendance counts of women in gram sabha and community meetings.
- Frequency of actual participation and vocal input of women during planning discussions.
- Level of freedom exhibited by women to express opinions openly without looking for male validation.
- Explicit behavioral response and respect of male members toward women's suggestions.
- Manifested confidence level and independent leadership behavior of elected women representatives.
- The definitive role and authority exerted by women during final decision-making processes.

Focus Group Discussion (FGD) Prompts

- What distinct changes have you noticed in women's public participation over the past few years?
- Are women genuinely able to take independent development decisions in the village, or do male relatives act as proxies?
- What are the major social and cultural barriers preventing women from seeking leadership?
- How do village-level self-help groups (SHGs) support women's individual and financial empowerment?
- Do government schemes and reservations efficiently help women participate in local governance?
- What specific structural improvements are needed to strengthen women's leadership in rural Jharkhand?

Detailed Data Analysis Plan

- The collected primary data will be structured and analyzed using both qualitative and quantitative research methodologies.
- **Questionnaire Analysis (Quantitative):** Information obtained through the structured questionnaire modules will be scrutinized, classified, and tabulated using the percentage and tabulation method. The primary purpose of this analysis is to examine the definitive level of women's physical participation in decision-making bodies.
- **Interview Schedule Analysis (Qualitative):** Data collected from scheduled personal interviews will be analyzed through descriptive analysis. The core purpose is to understand women's raw experiences, personal opinions, and structural challenges within local bodies.
- **Focus Group Discussion Analysis (Qualitative):** Interactive group data collected from FGD sessions will be processed using thematic analysis. This will serve the explicit purpose of identifying social barriers and supportive factors affecting women's local leadership.
- **Observation Data Analysis (Qualitative):** Field notes gathered using the observation method will be evaluated through interpretative analysis. The analytical purpose is to study the actual real-time participation, behavioral assertion, and genuine involvement of women in local governance activities.
- **Secondary Sources Analysis (Descriptive):** Background information gathered from published works will be processed through comparative analysis. The direct purpose is to support the field study findings through established books, government reports, and published research articles.
- **Collected Data Synthesis (Integrated):** The complete body of information will be processed via qualitative and quantitative analysis. The ultimate purpose of this step is to draw empirical research conclusions and provide practical suggestions for improving women's participation.

Ethical Considerations and Pilot Testing

- **Informed Consent:** Every participant will be informed about the academic nature of the study, and explicit voluntary consent will be obtained prior to interviewing.
- **Confidentiality and Privacy:** No personal identifiers or addresses will be disclosed in the chapter logs; alpha-numeric coding will be utilized to protect respondent identities from political or family friction.
- **Pilot Testing Procedure:** The interview schedules and questionnaires will be pre-tested on 5 non-sample respondents within Chhattarpur block to adjust contextual wording, track average completion duration, and ensure structural reliability.

Chapter Plan

Chapter: Introduction

- Background of the Study
- Introduction to the Topic

- Statement of the Problem
- Significance of the Study
- Objectives of the Study
- Hypothesis of the Study
- Scope of the Study
- Limitations of the Study
- Definition of Key Terms

Chapter: Review of Literature

- Concept of Women's Participation
- Decision-Making Bodies and Governance
- Review of Previous Research Studies
- Role of Women in Rural Governance
- Barriers to Women's Participation
- Supportive Factors for Women's Leadership
- Research Gap

Chapter: Research Methodology

- Research Design
- Study Area
- Sampling Method
- Sources of Data
- Tools for Data Collection
- Questionnaire and Interview Schedule
- Method of Data Collection
- Data Analysis Method

Chapter: Data Analysis and Interpretation

- Classification of Collected Data
- Tabulation of Data
- Analysis of Questionnaire Responses
- Analysis of Interview Responses
- Interpretation of FGD Findings
- Observation Analysis
- Discussion of Major Findings

Chapter: Findings, Conclusion, and Suggestions

- Major Findings of the Study
- Conclusion
- Recommendations
- Policy Suggestions
- Scope for Further Research

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Date of Approval: _____